

Lecturas y Conversaciones

A Year in Books | Club Summary & Session Highlights



A READER'S LOG

Libre



Lea Ypi

Growing Up in the Ruins of History

Session 1 | 5th May

Book: *Free (Libre)* by Lea Ypi

The Context

A memoir of coming of age in post-communist Albania (1990). Ypi details the jarring transition from childhood innocence to adult complexity amidst the fall of a regime.

The Discussion

The group explored the clash between freedom and loyalty, and how identity shifts in a repressive versus chaotic political environment. Voices focused on what was learned about the internal and external conflicts of Albania's transition.



Madness as a Metaphor

Session 2 | 2nd June

Book: Delirium (Delirio) by Laura Restrepo

The Context

Colombia in the 1980s. A story exploring the intersection of personal madness and collective trauma involving narcos, violence, and family secrets.

The Verdict

The group discussed the fragmented, non-linear narrative that forces the reader to reconstruct the truth.

Character Study

- Agustina: Victim, medium, or symbol of the country?
- Midas McAlister: The link to the narco world and power.
- Nicolás: The grandfather representing a destructive legacy.

"Who is the most dangerous character? Who is the most human?"

Borracha menor

sofía
balbuena



The Discomfort of Intimacy

Session 3 | 4th July

Book: *Borracha menor* by Sofía Balbuena

The Context

A debut novel (2022) by an Argentine writer, recognized as a 'disruptive new voice'.

The Verdict

A debate on the sensory reading experience—was it uncomfortable, revealing, or tough? The narrative centers on toxic relationships and the protagonist's relationship with alcohol.

Annie Ernaux
EL LUGAR

colección andanzas



Writing Without Judgment

Session 4

Book: *A Man's Place (El lugar)* by Annie Ernaux

The Context

An examination of the author's father and the class transition that separated them. Moderated successfully by Elena.

The Verdict

Generally liked, with many members identifying personally with the author's experience. The key discussion focused on Ernaux's "dry" writing style—debating if it was too cold, or the perfect vehicle for the subject matter.

The True Story Behind the Fiction

Session 5 | Betty by Tiffany McDaniel



The Family House



Leland, Fraya, Trustin, Flossie



Betty



Childhood

Narrative: A deep dive into the author's family history, Cherokee heritage, tragedy, and resilience.

David Uclés
LA PENÍNSULA
DE LAS CASAS VACÍAS

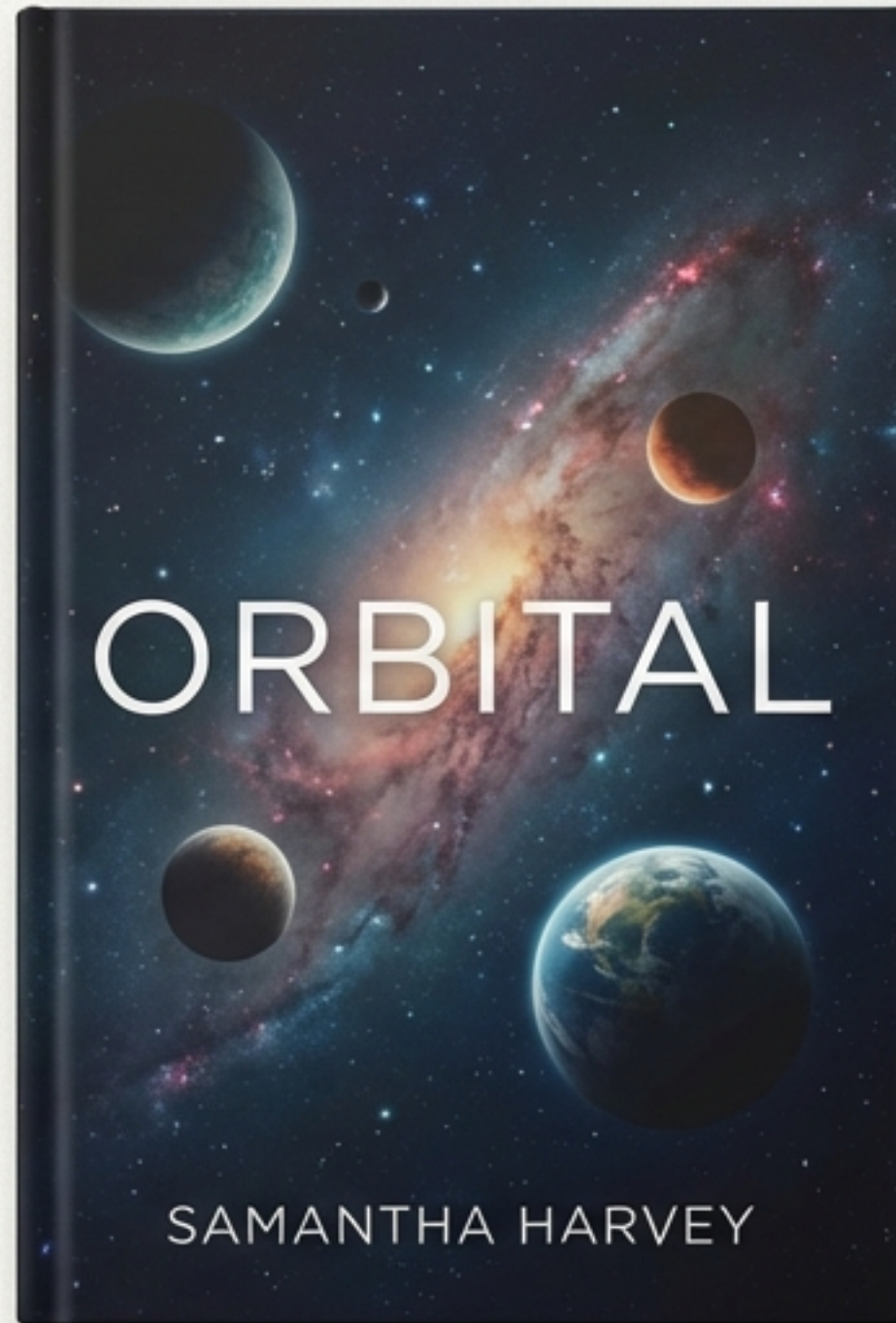
Siruela Nuevos Tiempos



Echoes of the Past

Session 6 | 11th November

Book: *The Peninsula of Empty Houses*
(*La península de las casas vacías*)
by David Uclés



The Fragility of Earth

Session 7

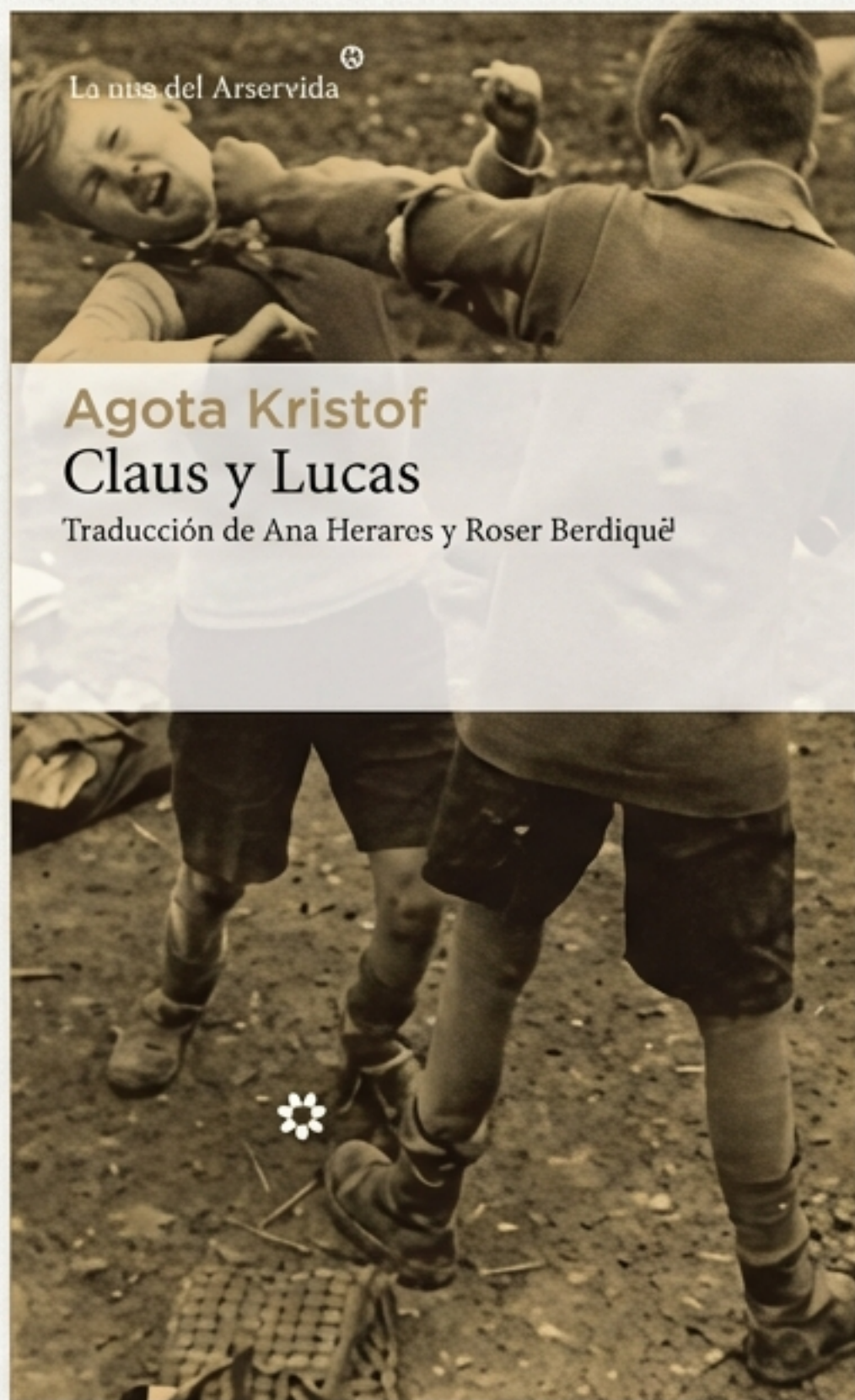
Book: *Orbital* by Samantha Harvey

The Verdict: Divisive

Opinions split sharply. Marina (with Elena, Ana, Cris) found it suggestive and poetic. Others struggled to engage, with Vane finding the space setting frightening rather than fascinating.

Key Insight: Duality

Elena highlighted the contrast between the uncomfortable, claustrophobic wires inside the ship versus the placid beauty of Earth outside. A reflection on how borders visible on maps vanish when seen from orbit.



The Anatomy of Cruelty

Session 9 | 20th January

Book: *The Notebook Trilogy (Claus and Lucas)* by Agota Kristof

The Verdict: A Descending Curve

1. The Notebook: Unanimously liked. Powerful, crude, and impactful.
2. The Proof: Irregular and disconcerting.
3. The Third Lie: The least convincing; low resonance.

Themes

Abandonment, 'The Witch,' and the complex portrayal of sexuality. The group noted the "dry" narrative style—facts presented without moral judgment.

Threads Through the Tapestry

Recurring themes in our year of reading

Trauma & History

The group consistently gravitated toward stories set in the ruins of history—from Post-Communist Albania (Free) to 80s Colombia (Delirio) and WWII Europe (The Notebook).

Family Dynamics

The weight of heritage and family tension was a central force in Betty, Delirio, and A Man's Place.

Stylistic Experiments

The year was defined by difficult structures—from the fragmented timelines in Delirio to the 'objective' dry narration of Ernaux and Kristof.

The Next Chapter

1. The Protocol

Remember to prepare 1–3 book proposals for the end of the next session.

2. Moderation

We are looking for new volunteers to rotate the moderator role.

3. Next Steps

Prepare your proposals.



Happy Reading!

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